Marco Polo hailed the Pandyan Kingdom as 'the richest and the most splendid province in the world'. Together with Ceylon, he added, it 'produced most of the gems and pearls that are found in the world'. In his travel account he recorded the incidents of *sati* and the polygamy practiced by the kings.

Sadaiyavarman Sundarapandyan

The illustrious ruler of the second Pandya Kingdom was Sadaiyavarman (Jatavarman) Sundarapandyan (1251 to 1268). He brought the entire Tamil Nadu under his rule, which extended up to Nellore in Andhra. He held the Hoysalas in check. The Chera ruler, the chief of *Malanadu,* accepted his feudatory position and paid tribute to Sundarapandyan. Emboldened by the decline of the Chola state, the Boja King of Malwa region Vira Someswara challenged Sundarapandyan. In a war at Kannanur, Sundarapandyan defeated Someswara. Sundarapandyan succeeded in establishing his authority over the chieftains of Cuddalore, Kanchipuram in Northern Tamil Nadu, Arcot and Salem in the western region.



Coin of Pandya Kingdom

There were two or three co-regents who ruled simultaneously along with Sundarapandyan: VikramaPandyan and ViraPandyan. After Sundarapandyan, Maravarman Kulasekaran ruled successfully for a period of 40 years , giving the country peace and prosperity. He had two sons. The king's appointment of ViraPandyan as a co-regent provoked the other son Sundara Pandyan, who killed his father Maravarman Kulasekaran. In the civil war that ensued, ViraPandyan won and became firmly established in his kingdom. The defeated SundaraPandyan fled to Delhi and took refuge under the protection of Ala-ud-din Khalji. This provided the opening for the invasion of Malik Kafur.

After Malik Kafur's invasion, the Pandyan Kingdom was divided among a number of kings from the main ruling Pandya's family. In Madurai, a Muslim State subordinate to the Delhi Sultan came to be established.

Polity and Society

State

Pandya kings preferred Madurai as their capital. Madurai has been popularly venerated as *Koodal*. The kings are traditionally revered as *Koodal-kon*, *Koodal Nagar Kavalan*. The Pandyas derived military advantage over their neighbours by means of their horses. They imported these horses from Arabs with whom they had commercial and cultural contacts.

The king claimed that he was ruling according to Manu Sastra. This doctrine supported the social hierarchy in the society. Kings and local chiefs created Brahmin settlements called *Mangalam* or *Chatur-vedi-mangalam* with irrigation facilities.

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